Team Rules for OpenAI Codex with AGENTS.md



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Author Audition

Overview



What if your newest teammate forgot everything, every hour?

That's how Codex starts every task, unless you give it a note.

WHAT'S IN IT FOR YOU

Codex pull requests that follow your team's rules the first time.

THE STORY



Monday: Sam joins the team



Maliha
Tech lead



Sam
New developer

TEAM NOTES FOR SAM

- ☐ **Bad input? Raise AppError with a code.**
- ☐ **Test with the team command.**
- ☐ **Add a line to CHANGELOG.md.**

20 minutes.
Sam remembers all week.

Author Audition

Tuesday: Codex joins.
Nobody onboards it.

The review ping-pong

Codex: PR #57: add apply_coupon()

Maliha: Use AppError, not ValueError.

Codex: Fixed.

Maliha: Where are the tests?

Codex: Added.

Maliha: And the CHANGELOG.md line?

3
rounds

Next task. Same three comments.

Task 1: Coupons	Task 2: Gift cards	Task 3: Refunds	Task 4: Shipping
Use AppError	Use AppError	Use AppError	Use AppError
Add tests	Add tests	Add tests	Add tests
Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG	Update CHANGELOG

For Codex, every task is day one.

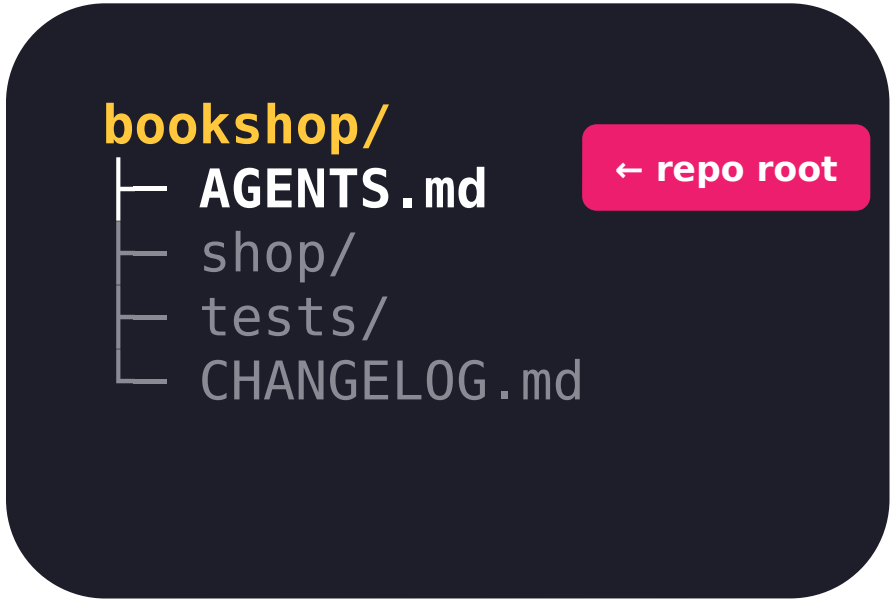
“Codex isn't bad at our rules.
It has never read them.”

Maliha, after the third review round

AGENTS.md

A Markdown file in your repo that Codex reads before every task. The onboarding note for a teammate who starts fresh each time.

Where it lives, and when Codex reads it



Committed in Git: the whole team shares it.

1 A task starts

↓

2 Codex reads AGENTS.md

↓

3 Then your prompt

Changed the file? Start a new thread.

Turn Sam's notes into rules Codex can check

Told to Sam	Written for Codex
"Handle errors properly"	**Raise AppError with an UPPER_SNAKE code**
"Remember to test"	**Run: python -m unittest discover -s tests -v**
"Keep docs updated"	**One CHANGELOG.md line under Unreleased**

The test for every rule: could a reviewer check it in the diff?

Maliha's AGENTS.md

```
# Bookshop team rules

- Money is Decimal, never float.
- Invalid input: raise AppError with an UPPER_SNAKE code.
- Public functions: docstring with an Example: line.
- Before finishing, run: python -m unittest discover -s tests -v
- Add one line to CHANGELOG.md under ## Unreleased.
- Do not add dependencies.
```

← round 1

← round 2

← round 3

Every review comment became a rule. Plain Markdown, about ten lines.



Demo



Prove it: the same prompt, twice

1. **NO NOTE**
   Ask Codex to add apply_coupon
2. **CHECK THE DIFF**
   Would Maliha leave the same 3 comments?
3. **ADD AGENTS.md**
   Copy the note to the repo root
4. **SAME PROMPT**
   New thread, identical words
5. **COMPARE**
   Did Codex follow the rules?

Friday: one review, zero ping-pong

PR #58: add apply_coupon()

- ✓ **raise AppError("INVALID_COUPON")**
- ✓ **Docstring with an Example: line**
- ✓ **Tests run with the team command**
- ✓ **CHANGELOG.md updated**

Approved.
No comments needed.

Same prompt as Tuesday.
One Markdown file changed.

Your turn

What's in your team's onboarding notes
that Codex has never read?



Summary



Codex starts every task like a new hire

AGENTS.md is its onboarding note

Write rules a reviewer can check

Rules guide Codex. Review still checks